any kind of dangerous disturbance given the conditions they were held in was a mystery, but the ‘QRF soldiers will don riot control gear consisting of: face shields attached to the Kevlar, non-ballistic shin guards, a shield, and a baton’. The manual shows how fear at the highest level can inform brutality: these prisoners were not treated like normal opponents or normal men, they were to be handled like Hollywood supervillains who posed, as they lived and breathed, the most extraordinary security risk ever encountered. They must be kept like demons and patrolled by dogs. One detainee was forced to wear women’s underwear on his head. Psychological torture was rampant. And the manual made it clear that disorientation and humiliation were understood to be part of common practice. The insecurity present in all of this is truly staggering; it tells you about America under Bush, a place that appeared willing to suspend all its constitutional decencies in the effort to annihilate the phantoms of danger. These techniques, as later reported in the *Washington Post*, informed the way things were done at Abu Ghraib. Cruelty and hatred live inside individuals, but when I talk about ‘injustice’ I am making an observation about a political and social system. The torture techniques used at Abu Ghraib were not invented by a few working-class American military policemen and women who were later conveniently scapegoated. They were part of the system and the moral responsibility starts at the top.

We released this manual without fanfare and with little introduction. It didn’t need anything – at first glance you saw how explosive it was. Nothing happened for a week and then we got a letter from Southern Command, who are responsible for Guantánamo, asking us to remove it. That was good news: it proved the publication’s authenticity. We ignored it. Then *Wired* magazine picked up the story and later the *New York Times* and the *Washington Post*. It was the way I’d always expected word to get out, bubbling up from blogs and smaller press and into the mainstream. At first, when the heat came, it didn’t come directly to me. I was called Investigations Editor, and there wasn’t yet the habit, which has now become a contagion, of linking every WikiLeaks utterance to me. At the time I think I knew that my past, as a convicted hacker, wouldn’t necessarily help the cause we’d undertaken, and I wanted to keep my position dark as far as possible. But the rules of showbusiness, and, it must be said, the wiles of treachery, made it predictable that I should become the Bond villain and the designated bogeyman.